

Kai Wu

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EDUCATION

The University of Texas at Austin , Ph.D. in Economics	Aug. 2021 – Present
Jinan University , M.A. in Economics	Sept. 2018 – Jun. 2021
Northwest University (China) , B.A. in Economics	Sept. 2014 – Jun. 2018

RESEARCH FIELDS

Public Economics, Networks, Environmental Economics, Urban Economics

REFERENCES

Marika Cabral (Primary) Department of Economics UT Austin marika.cabral@utexas.edu	Nitya Pandalai-Nayar Department of Economics UT Austin npnayar@utexas.edu	Jackson Dorsey Department of Economics UT Austin jackson.dorsey@austin.utexas.edu
Cody Tuttle Department of Economics UT Austin cody.tuttle@utexas.edu	Ben Zou Department of Economics Purdue University zou136@purdue.edu	

WORKING PAPERS

Crowding (with Yizhen Gu, Qu Tang, and Ben Zou) [Job Market Paper]

Abstract: Crowding is a common disamenity, yet little is known about its monetary cost. We estimate the willingness to pay (WTP) to avoid crowding in public transit with a revealed-preference approach. Beijing Subway passengers choose departure times, trading off fare, in-train crowding, and schedule deviation, with price variation from an early-bird discount. Leveraging the subway's network structure, we impute real-time in-train crowding, infer each passenger's optimal arrival time, and construct a novel instrumental variable for crowding. The marginal WTP to reduce crowding by one passenger per square meter is about 0.05 RMB per minute, implying a crowding externality comparable to the fare. High-income passengers have higher crowding WTP but are less price-sensitive. An optimal crowding tax improves welfare within the subway system but is regressive; a two-class configuration elicits self-selection and benefits both high- and low-income commuters.

Political Consolidation and Corporate Tax Burden

SELECTED WORK IN PROGRESS

Beyond Targeted Firms: Supply Chain Spillovers of Environmental Regulation in China (with Xinghua Deng)

This project studies how the costs of environmental regulation propagate along supply chains beyond the targeted firms. Exploiting the 2017 Xiong'an pollution shutdown campaign in China together with ad-

ministrative firm-to-firm transaction data, it examines how the shock transmits to upstream suppliers and downstream customers, and whether losing a trading partner leads firms to contract trade with their remaining partners on both the input and the output side. A general equilibrium production-network model with scale economies links these firm-level responses to the design of environmental policy, comparing emissions taxes with quantity-based regulation.

Stock Market Turbulence and Production Networks (with Husang Kim and Rikuto Onishi)

Research question: Does non-fundamental stock price volatility propagate through production networks?

CONFERENCE AND SEMINAR PRESENTATIONS

(* indicates scheduled) UT Austin; ABFER Annual Conference; SEA Annual Meeting* (nominated student)	2026
Texas Applied Microeconomics Student Workshop	2025

FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS

Summer Excellence Fellowship, Graduate School, The University of Texas at Austin	2026
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TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant, The University of Texas at Austin

Introduction to Microeconomics	2021, 2022, 2024, 2026
Urban Economics	2022
Business Strategy	2023
Industrial Organization	2023
Economics of Education	2025
Energy and Environmental Economics	2025

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant for Prof. Yizhen Gu	2018–2021
Research Assistant for Prof. Marika Cabral	2023–2025

SKILLS

Software: Stata, Python, R, ArcGIS, QGIS, L^AT_EX

Languages: English (fluent), Chinese (native)